My current engagement with artificial intelligence has largely treated models as pure black boxes. I feed in data tune, collecting outputs, and interpreting results. But the deeper mechanics of why a particular architecture converges, or how optimization landscapes behave, or what makes one model generalize better than another have remained outside my working understanding. This is a gap that I believe cannot be closed with current coursework. It requires deliberately stepping into a more theoretically rigorous environment, and the exchange program at Seoul National University offers exactly that.

The courses I am most interested in at SNU operate at the graduate level, covering areas like neural network theory, optimization and NLP from a mathematical perspective. I am aware that as an undergraduate, enrolling in these requires instructor permission, and that I would be entering a classroom designed for Master’s and PhD students. This is a strategic choice. SNU is part of Korea’s most competitive group of universities. Being the least experienced person in the room is not a risk I am trying to avoid, it is the condition I am looking for because I consider it to be the fastest way to raise my personal standards.

One aspect of SNU's environment that particularly draws me in is the culture of seminar based learning that runs alongside formal coursework. Unlike lecture heavy formats where understanding is measured by examinations, SNU's graduate seminars are built around presenting papers, defending interpretations, and engaging in direct critique with peers and faculty. I believe that this format would prove extremely useful. Firstly, it forces a kind of active comprehension that passive study does not. I cannot hide behind familiarity with results if I am expected to explain the reasoning behind them. Secondly, being regularly exposed to how experienced researchers read and question a paper will train a critical instinct I currently lack. Lastly, the constant collaborations with peers would expand both my professional network and my capacity for teamwork in a research context.

By the end of this exchange, I expect to return with a clearer and more grounded sense of what I still need to learn, a stronger theoretical foundation to build on, and a much more honest picture of what serious AI research actually demands. That, more than any single course or credential, is what this program represents for me.